Database Services Roadmap

Discovery-to-Delivery Working Guide

Prepared for: Portfolio Architecture — Database Services | July 2026

A practical companion for building your first database services roadmap: how to run the effort, what to ask your Database Product Owner and EA Database Portfolio Architect, what's happening in the industry right now, and a roadmap structure adapted from the approach that already won executive approval for your cloud roadmap.

Contents

1. Purpose of This Guide

You've done this once before — the cloud roadmap already proved you can take a blank page to executive approval and applause. This guide applies the same discipline to database services, a domain you're picking up from scratch. It is organized as four working tools you can use in sequence:

1. An end-to-end process plan — the phases, sequencing, and rough timeline for the whole effort.
2. A discovery framework — the questions to bring into working sessions with the Database Product Owner and the EA Database Portfolio Architect.
3. An industry landscape primer — a fast-start briefing on where database technology and services stand today, so you're conversant before those sessions.
4. A roadmap structure/template — adapted from your cloud roadmap's approach, with database-specific themes (governance, licensing, migration risk) built in.

One note before you start: share your actual cloud roadmap deck or document with me when you have it. Everything below is built from general EA best practice plus current market research — once I can see your real roadmap's structure, narrative arc, and visual style, I can tailor this guide (and the eventual deck) to match it much more precisely.

2. End-to-End Process Plan

Treat this as a working plan, not a rigid schedule — compress phases where your cloud-roadmap muscle memory already covers the ground (stakeholder management, exec storytelling, governance cadence). Expect roughly 4–4.5 months from kickoff to executive sign-off if run mostly sequentially; less if phases 1 and 2 run in parallel.

Phase	Duration	Key Activities	Output
0. Framing & Sponsorship	1–2 wks	Confirm the vision/goal statement from the Product Owner; define scope boundaries (RDBMS, NoSQL, DBaaS, data warehouse, on-prem vs. cloud); agree the roadmap horizon; confirm executive sponsor and check-in cadence.	Charter + scope statement
1. Discovery & Current-State Assessment	4–6 wks	Working sessions with PO and Portfolio Architect: estate inventory (engines, versions, hosting, licensing), cost baseline, pain points, ongoing initiatives, compliance constraints, skills/staffing.	Current-state dossier
2. External Landscape & Benchmarking	2–3 wks (can run parallel to Phase 1)	Technology trend scan (see Section 4); hyperscaler/vendor capability comparison; peer/industry benchmarking; standards-body	Landscape brief

Phase	Duration	Key Activities	Output
		input.	
3. Gap Analysis & Opportunity ID	2 wks	Compare current state to the vision; group findings into strategic themes; prioritize with a value / effort / risk view.	Prioritized opportunity list
4. Roadmap Synthesis & Validation	3 wks	Draft the roadmap (horizons, initiatives, dependencies, owners); socialize with PO and Portfolio Architect; refine based on feedback.	Draft roadmap v1
5. Executive Narrative & Packaging	2 wks	Build the story arc (vision → current state → why change → roadmap → the ask); build the deck; pressure-test with a small group before the full exec session.	Exec-ready deck
6. Executive Presentation & Approval	1 wk	Present; capture feedback and conditions of approval; adjust as needed.	Approved roadmap
7. Governance & Tracking Setup	Ongoing	Establish a quarterly review cadence, KPI tracking, and clear ownership handoff to the Database Product Owner and Portfolio Architect for execution.	Governance model

What tends to make phase 4–6 succeed

- **Pre-wire, don't surprise.** Validate the draft with your PO and Portfolio Architect — and ideally one or two exec-adjacent sponsors — before the big reveal, the same way you likely de-risked the cloud roadmap presentation.
- **Keep the ask concrete.** Executives approve funding and priority, not slideware — each roadmap theme needs a clear ask (budget, headcount, decision) attached.
- **Separate the story from the backup.** A tight narrative deck for the room, with a detailed appendix (inventory, cost model, dependency map) for anyone who wants to go deeper.

3. Discovery Framework — Questions for Your Working Sessions

Use these as a starting agenda for sessions with the Database Product Owner (business/product lens) and the EA Database Portfolio Architect (technical/architectural lens). Not every question suits both audiences — skim and pick.

3.1 Vision & Strategic Alignment

- What business outcomes should this roadmap enable over the horizon — revenue growth, cost reduction, risk reduction, speed to market?
- How should the database roadmap connect to (or lean on) the existing cloud roadmap — shared landing zones, network, IAM, FinOps model?
- Is there an existing enterprise data strategy or governance framework this roadmap must align to?
- Who are the key consumers of database services today — application teams, analytics, AI/ML, external partners?

3.2 Current-State Inventory

- What's the full inventory of database engines in use, by type — relational, NoSQL/document, in-memory, graph, vector, data warehouse?
- What share is on-prem vs. cloud-hosted vs. fully managed DBaaS?
- What are the versions and end-of-life status of major platforms?
- What's the licensing exposure (Oracle, SQL Server, etc.) and when do major contracts renew?
- What's the current cost baseline — licensing, infrastructure, support, staffing?
- Which databases are mission-critical, and which are legacy candidates for retirement or consolidation?

3.3 Pain Points & Risk

- What are the top operational pain points today — performance, scalability, availability, patching, backup/DR?
- What compliance or regulatory exposure exists — data residency, PII, industry-specific regulation?
- What incidents or outages in the last 12 months trace back to database issues?
- Where are the single points of failure or key-person dependencies?

3.4 Demand & Emerging Needs

- What new workloads are coming — AI/ML, vector search, real-time analytics, IoT — that the current estate can't serve well?
- What's the appetite for data mesh or self-service data products?
- Are business units already requesting database technologies that aren't standardized or supported today?

3.5 Organization & Skills

- What's the current DBA/database engineering structure, and where are the skill gaps — especially for cloud-native ops, Kubernetes-based data services, vector databases?

- What's the sourcing model today — in-house, managed service provider, hyperscaler-managed — and should that change?

3.6 Constraints & Guardrails

- What's the budget envelope or cost tolerance for modernization?
- What's the organization's cloud provider strategy (single- vs. multi-cloud) that this roadmap must respect?
- What standards, security policies, or architecture review processes must every initiative comply with?
- What's the risk appetite for migrations — big-bang cutover vs. incremental/parallel-run?

3.7 Success Definition

- What does success look like at the end of year 1 vs. year 2?
- What metrics will track execution — cost savings, uptime, provisioning time, % modernized, licensing spend reduction?

4. Industry Landscape Primer — State of Database Services (2026)

A fast-start briefing so you can hold your own in the discovery sessions. Treat it as a starting point, not a substitute for what you'll learn from your own estate and stakeholders.

4.1 The Big Shifts

- **AI-readiness is now a first-class design goal.** Vector databases and vector-native engines (for embeddings and LLM retrieval) have moved from niche to mainstream enterprise requirement; "AI-ready" data increasingly means real-time, contextualized, and governed data products rather than static extracts.
- **Cloud-native and serverless are the default for new workloads.** Modern cloud-native databases (e.g., Neon, PlanetScale-style platforms) support horizontal scaling, automated failover, declarative management via Kubernetes operators, and integration with modern observability stacks. Serverless compute that auto-pauses/resumes is now common even in traditionally heavyweight platforms (e.g., Azure SQL Hyperscale).
- **Multi-model is displacing single-purpose sprawl.** Databases that support relational, document, graph, and vector workloads in one engine are reducing the need to run a separate specialized store for every data shape, though specialized services (time-series, graph) remain common for demanding workloads.
- **DBaaS adoption keeps accelerating.** The cloud database/DBaaS market was valued at roughly $25–26B in 2025 and is projected to grow at a mid-to-high-teens CAGR through the mid-2030s, as

organizations replace self-managed infrastructure with managed platforms for flexibility, speed, and lower operational overhead.

- **Governance is shifting from checklist to embedded control.** The emerging model is "federated computational governance" — central IT sets hard boundaries (security, compliance) while domains own their data products; governance is increasingly automated and embedded into pipelines rather than enforced after the fact. Zero-trust is becoming the default security posture for data environments.
- **Licensing economics are pushing migration off legacy platforms.** Oracle and SQL Server Enterprise licensing remains a major cost driver — Oracle's 2026 Standard Edition 2 changes made SE2 notably costlier, prompting many enterprises to re-evaluate. PostgreSQL has become the most-used database among developers and is now the default target for organizations exiting proprietary licenses, with documented cases of 60–80%+ run-cost reduction after migration.

4.2 Hyperscaler Database Portfolios (for benchmarking your own estate)

Provider	Notable Database Portfolio
AWS	Broadest portfolio: RDS (managed relational), Aurora (MySQL/PostgreSQL-compatible, high performance), DynamoDB (managed NoSQL), ElastiCache (Redis/Memcached), Neptune (graph), Timestream (time-series). Largest service breadth and partner ecosystem.
Microsoft Azure	Azure SQL Database (deep SQL Server compatibility, Hyperscale up to 100TB, serverless auto-pause), Cosmos DB (globally distributed, multiple consistency models), Azure Database for PostgreSQL Flexible Server (much improved feature parity).
Google Cloud	Cloud SQL (managed MySQL/PostgreSQL/SQL Server), Cloud Spanner (horizontally scalable, strongly consistent — a distinctive market position), AlloyDB (PostgreSQL-compatible, analytics-oriented).

4.3 Themes Worth Probing With Your Stakeholders

- Where does the current estate sit on the legacy-licensing exposure curve (Oracle/SQL Server Enterprise), and is a licensing renewal a forcing function you can use as a roadmap catalyst?
- Is there emerging, ungoverned demand for vector/AI-ready data stores from ML or analytics teams that the roadmap should get ahead of?
- Does the organization's multi-cloud posture (from the cloud roadmap) constrain or open up database placement options?
- What's the organization's actual governance maturity — checklist-based today, or ready to move toward embedded/automated controls?

Sources

- Cloud Database and DBaaS market analysis — datainsightsmarket.com, openpr.com
- On-prem DBaaS platforms and standards, 2026 — CNCF blog (cncf.io)
- Cloud-native database guide, 2026 — Tasrie IT Services
- 2026 data architecture, governance, and AI predictions — Cloudera blog
- Data modernization and enterprise data architecture guides, 2026 — ness.com, dataforest.ai, Alation
- AWS vs. Azure vs. GCP database service comparisons, 2026 — calmops.com, valley4techs.com, kodekloud.com
- Oracle SE2 licensing changes and PostgreSQL migration economics, 2026 — thenegotiationexperts.com, tech-insider.org, mactores.com, newtglobal.com

5. Roadmap Structure — Adapted From Your Cloud Roadmap

This mirrors the philosophy that already worked for you — vision, current state, themes, horizons, the ask — with database-specific concerns (governance, licensing, migration risk) built into the theme structure rather than bolted on.

5.1 Suggested Document / Deck Skeleton

5. Executive summary and vision statement (anchored on the Product Owner's goal statement)
6. Current-state summary — estate inventory, cost baseline, top pain points (1–2 pages, detail in appendix)
7. Strategic themes (see 5.2)
8. Horizon view — Now / Next / Later mapped to initiatives (see 5.3)
9. Initiative detail cards (see 5.4)
10. Dependency map — including explicit links to cloud roadmap items (landing zones, network, IAM, FinOps)
11. Investment view — cost and, where relevant, savings/avoidance by theme
12. Risk register
13. Governance and tracking cadence
14. Success metrics / KPIs

5.2 Candidate Strategic Themes

- **Modernize & consolidate legacy platforms —** reduce the footprint of end-of-life and high-licensing-cost engines.

- **Embrace DBaaS & cloud-native —** shift new and eligible existing workloads to managed, cloud-native services.
- **AI- and vector-readiness —** give ML/AI initiatives a supported, governed path to vector and real-time data.
- **Data governance & security by design —** embed classification, access control, and compliance into the data platform rather than as an overlay.
- **Cost optimization & licensing rationalization —** use renewal cycles and open-source alternatives to reduce run-cost.
- **Skills & operating model evolution —** close capability gaps and evolve the sourcing model (in-house / MSP / hyperscaler-managed).

Adjust these once discovery is complete — they're a starting hypothesis, not a conclusion.

5.3 Horizon View Template

Now (0–6 months)	Next (6–12 months)	Later (12–24 months)
Foundational, low-risk, high-visibility wins — e.g., estate inventory cleanup, quick licensing wins, pilot of one modernization pattern.	Initiatives that need Now-phase foundations — e.g., first production migrations, governance framework rollout, skills program launch.	Larger, higher-risk, or dependency-heavy initiatives — e.g., full legacy retirement, cross-domain data mesh rollout, multi-cloud database strategy maturity.

5.4 Initiative Detail Card (repeat per initiative)

Initiative name	—
Theme	—
Description	—
Business value / the ask	—
Dependencies	— (including cloud roadmap links)
Owner	—
Target horizon	—
Risk level & mitigation	—

5.5 Governance & Tracking Cadence

- Quarterly roadmap review with the Database Product Owner and EA Portfolio Architect — status, blockers, re-prioritization.
- Standing KPI dashboard (cost, modernization %, uptime, provisioning time) reviewed alongside the cloud roadmap's own cadence, if one exists, to keep the two roadmaps visibly connected.
- Change log for scope or timeline shifts, shared with the same executive audience that approved the original roadmap.

6. Carrying Forward What Worked Last Year

Since you don't yet have this year's counterpart to compare against, here are the general principles that tend to separate roadmaps that get approved and applauded from those that get politely acknowledged. Once you share your actual cloud roadmap, I can replace this with specifics from what you did.

- **A single sentence the room can repeat back.** The vision statement you're already requesting from the Product Owner should be able to stand alone as the one thing executives remember.
- **Current state told as a cost of inaction, not a data dump.** Inventory and pain points matter only insofar as they build the case for the themes that follow.
- **Themes that map cleanly to executive concerns.** Cost, risk, and speed — not technology for its own sake.
- **A visible connection to what's already approved.** Explicitly showing where this roadmap leans on cloud roadmap investments (landing zones, network, governance) reduces the perceived cost of the new ask.
- **Pre-socialization before the room.** Nothing in the executive session should be the first time a key stakeholder has seen it.

Appendix: Quick-Reference Checklist

- Vision/goal statement received from Database Product Owner
- Scope boundaries agreed (engines, hosting models, in/out of scope)
- Roadmap horizon agreed (recommend matching the 2-year cloud roadmap horizon)
- Discovery sessions scheduled with PO and EA Portfolio Architect
- Current-state inventory and cost baseline captured
- Landscape/benchmarking scan complete
- Strategic themes drafted and validated
- Roadmap draft socialized before executive session

- Governance/tracking cadence agreed for post-approval